Lab 06: Colour Harmony Poster

Level: Intermediate Suggested time: 60 minutes Platform: Complete the core brief in either Procreate or Sketchbook Studio; use the comparison notes to transfer the workflow. Alignment: K9 | A2 | A3 | LO2

Scenario

A local café needs three colourways for the same illustrated seasonal-drink poster.

Your role: Brand illustrator Required deliverable: Analogous, complementary and muted palette variants of one composition.

Learning goal

Apply Hue | saturation | value | harmony | palette roles | greyscale check to a real design decision and produce evidence that meets explicit acceptance criteria.

Before you begin

- Use an iPad that supports your chosen app and a compatible stylus where available.
- Save an editable, layered master before exporting a flattened image.
- Use only owned, licensed or clearly permitted reference images and record their sources.
- Create a folder named Lab-06-<YourName> for working files and evidence.

Part A - Plan and construct

1. Duplicate one approved café-poster composition so only colour-not layout-changes.
2. Create three palette plans: analogous, complementary and muted-with-accent.
3. Assign dominant, support, neutral and accent roles before painting.
4. Apply the same local values to each variant, then introduce the planned hues.
5. Reserve the highest saturation and largest local contrast for the product focal point.
6. Check each variant in greyscale and at thumbnail size; correct any lost message.
7. Recommend one colourway using audience fit, brand promise and legibility evidence.

Part B - Procreate pathway

1. Duplicate the finished composition three times in Gallery before recolouring.
2. Create named palettes in the Colour panel for analogous, complementary and muted variants.
3. Use selections, Alpha Lock or clipping layers to recolour cleanly without redrawing.
4. Use Adjustments → Hue, Saturation, Brightness or Gradient Map only as controlled tests on duplicates.
5. Create a temporary greyscale check with a top layer or exported proof; do not flatten the master.
6. Compare at fit-to-screen and thumbnail size, not only zoomed in.
7. Export three consistently named PNGs and a contact sheet.

Part C - Sketchbook Studio pathway

1. Duplicate the layered poster twice to create three colour variants.

2. Use the full colour picker to set dominant, support, neutral and accent swatches.
3. Recolour on separate layers or duplicated colour layers; avoid repainting the line layer.
4. Use Mono as a temporary duplicated-layer/filter check for value readability.
5. Use Vibrant sparingly as a comparison, then choose deliberate colours manually.
6. Compare each version at reduced zoom and record the recommended palette.
7. Export three consistently named images and the layered originals.

Evidence and acceptance checklist

[ ] Three variants retain the same composition

[ ] Primary message survives greyscale

[ ] Accent colour is used selectively

[ ] Recommended palette justified for the audience

[ ] Layered working file is saved and opens correctly.

[ ] Final export uses a clear filename and matches the intended dimensions.

[ ] At least one in-progress screenshot shows the technique in use.

[ ] Reference sources and design decisions are recorded.

Peer review questions

1. Which palette attracts first attention?
2. Which palette best matches the café promise?
3. What trade-off exists between excitement and readability?

Debrief

Use the Observe → Interpret → Connect → Propose pattern:

1. Observe: State what is visible without praise or blame.
2. Interpret: Explain the likely effect on attention, meaning, emotion or use.
3. Connect: Link the effect to the brief, a design principle or the acceptance criteria.
4. Propose: Name one specific change and how you will check whether it works.

Record one decision you will keep, one change you will test, and one technique you can transfer to the other app.

Troubleshooting

- The line feels wobbly: Zoom out, slow the decision rather than the stroke, use shoulder movement, and increase stabilisation only enough to preserve intent.
- Colour leaks during fill: Close the contour, inspect gaps at 100%, or place colour on a separate layer and clean with the precise eraser.
- The file becomes hard to edit: Name or document layer roles, hide unused experiments, group related stages and duplicate before merging or filtering.
- The image looks muddy: Check value grouping, lower overlay opacity, remove competing texture and restore one clear focal contrast.

- Perspective feels wrong: Return to horizon and vanishing logic; correct the large box before windows, props or decoration.

Submission package

Submit Lab-06-<YourName>/ containing:

- layered working file (or the app's saved layered sketch);
- final PNG/JPEG/PDF as required by the brief;
- progress evidence/contact sheet;
- short design rationale answering the peer-review questions; and
- reference/provenance list.

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